Alcoholics Anonymous Paper
Kelly Ryan
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The Alcoholics Anonymous group I attended, hereafter referred to as AA, was a one-hour self-help group at Skipwith United Methodist Church. This AA group was unique in that it was an all female group. The group of people who attended was very diverse, despite the fact that they were all women. Even though this was my first AA meeting, I felt welcomed and will definitely mention the Skipwith location to female patients as needed.

AA offers many purposes including the main goal of attaining and maintaining sobriety, instilling hope, allowing for catharsis, allowing for resolution of family issues and to foster universality (Townsend, 2014). It seemed the above purposes were met as many people stated that attending AA meetings helped them remain sober or helped them drastically reduce their drinking. As mentioned later in this paper, others felt a great sense of hope from the meetings. Several women cried during this meeting as they explored unresolved familial issues and experienced catharsis.

The seating structure of this group was ideal for an AA meeting. The tables and chairs were set up in a circular fashion that was very open. This allowed everyone to feel involved and connected with one another. The size of this group was also ideal. This group of about

thirty women allowed for individual input but was also large enough that people did not need to speak if they did not want to speak.

The group consisted of about thirty mostly white women from the approximate ages of 25-55, from all backgrounds and socioeconomic status. This group also represented different aspects of sexuality, as both gay and straight women were members of this AA group. The population who attended the AA group is the composition to be expected for an all female group as alcoholism does take time to develop so I would not expect the clients to be very young. It is also expected that various socio-economic classes be represented as alcoholism effects people from all classes.

Step 1 of Alcoholics Anonymous is to admit that you are an alcoholic and that you are powerless in your use of the drug (Townsend, 2014). This is a key step because one must admit that a problem exists in order for changes to be made. The importance of Step 1 of AA was modeled when people introduced themselves before speaking throughout the entire meeting. Before anyone spoke they said their name followed by the words, “and I’m an alcoholic.”

Although several of Yaslom’s curative factors could be described as part of this AA group, “cohesion” and “instillation of hope” seem to be key factors of this particular group of women. These women have described that previously in their lives they never felt like they were a part of a group, or that the group they were a part of did not support

their life goals and dreams. These women now describe the cohesiveness of the group as they highly value their AA group and many consider this group their family. A continuous theme at the AA group I attended was the importance of hope. The women described their lives while they struggled with alcohol abuse as “hopeless” and “out of control”. Many mentioned that during the beginning of their recovery process it was difficult to have hope, even though they knew they should. The “instillation of hope” was a huge step that seemed to motivate these women to remain sober and it gave them the strength to believe they could remain sober.

I recommend that these clients stick with the AA program as many of them have been sober for years with the help of the meetings. Some of them mentioned during the meeting that through AA they have remained sober for over 20 years. However, as a whole research shows a person who decides to stop drinking alcohol altogether has a greater amount of success in remaining sober than if they are to use a self-help group such as use AA (Kaskutas, 2009).

My expectations of attending the AA meeting were met and surpassed. I was reluctant to attend the meeting, however I found the group to be very uplifting. The women were respectful of each other and seemed to truly appreciate the presence and insight offered by other members. I have never been to an AA meeting but I formed an expectation of what it might be like through media and cultural

interpretations. For example, I expected there to be one leader for the meeting and for people to share experiences about their struggle with alcohol, both of which were present at the meeting I attended. In summary, I am thankful I chose to attend the Skipwith United Methodist Alcoholics Anonymous group and would highly recommend it to female patients.

References:

Kaskutas, L. *J Addict Dis*. 2009 ; 28(2): 145–157. doi:10.1080/10550880902772464.

Townsend, M. (2014) *Psychiatric Mental Health Nursing: Concepts of Care in Evidence-Based Practice edition 8.0. Philadelphia, PA: F. A. Davis Company*